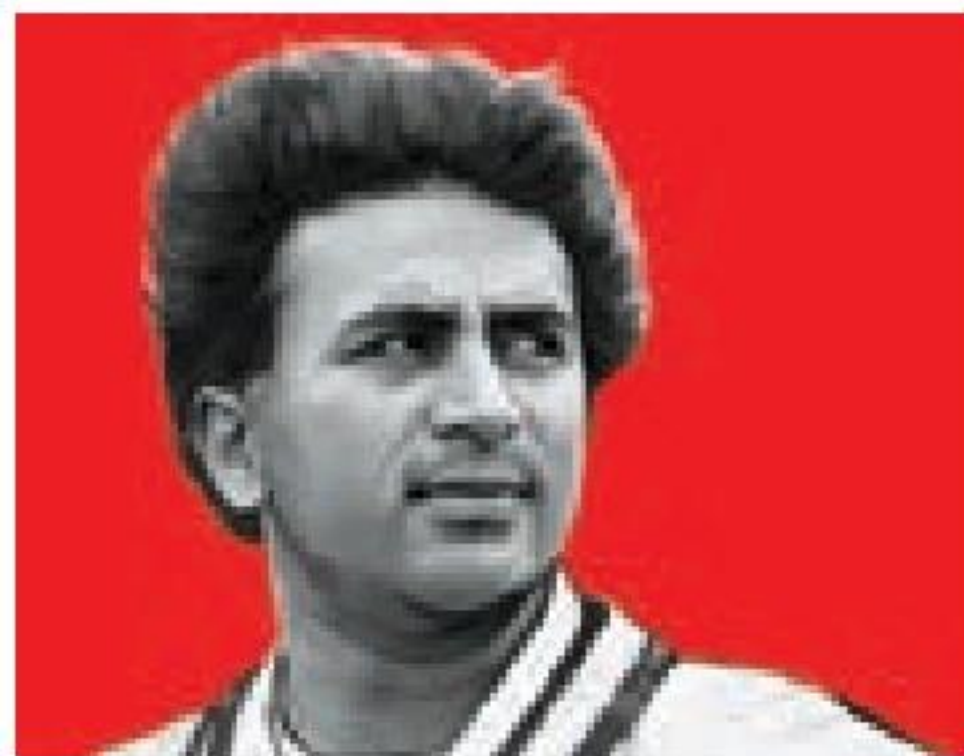




ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



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IT WILL TAKE A REALLY BAD DAY AT THE OFFICE FOR THIS INDIAN TEAM TO BE DEFEATED

It's not just the wins but the manner of those wins that will be making the coaches and think tank of other teams scratch their heads as to how to stop what looks like a **juggernaut**.

India will be looking to complete a clean sweep of the T20 series against New Zealand and, in doing so, send a message to the rest of the cricketing world that they are more than ready to defend the ICC World Cup they won in 2024. It is not just the wins, but the manner of those wins, that will be making the coaches and think tanks of other teams scratch their heads over how to stop what looks like a juggernaut.

Of course, in this ultra-short format of the game, one good over in either innings can turn a match on its head, so nothing is guaranteed. But the Indian team is playing some incredible cricket, and it will take a really bad day at the office for them to be defeated.

The comprehensive win in Guwahati showed just why this team is to be feared. It was as complete a performance as one could hope to see. The bowling was outstanding and the catching superb, with former captain Hardik Pandya leading the way with a catch that set

the standard for the rest of the day. The ground fielding, the throwing and the backing up were all champion-class. Then came the chase and, despite losing Sanju Samson to the first ball of the innings, the left-handed duo of Abhishek Sharma and Ishan Kishan counter-attacked in a manner that was simply awesome. Awesome because even good deliveries were being dispatched to and over the boundary. In such a scenario, the bowler is left clueless about what line and length to bowl, and the Guwahati Stadium boundaries were not short either.

Skipper Suryakumar Yadav got a classy half-century in the previous game, and he continued in that vein, showing that the ball is now meeting the middle of the bat more regularly and going exactly where he is aiming.

He is an instinctive skipper, and his calm demeanour eases the players' thought processes as they are encouraged to play the way they know best. As a captain, it is relatively easy to set fields for good deliveries, but SKY